

Story 3 : The 1975 Hippie Trail and the Beirut War Zone Escape

In 1975, long before the era of digital nomads and luxury backpacking, a 21-year-old Bob Campana left his predictable life in the Sierra Nevada foothills to travel the globe. Armed with a \$2,300 Pan Am around-the-world ticket, a 30-pound backpack, and \$4,000 in traveler's checks hidden in a money belt, he set out to see how the rest of humanity lived. His journey started in Jakarta, Indonesia, where he was hosted by a wealthy executive in a mansion surrounded by spiked concrete walls and armed guards. But within a day, Bob left that bubble and threw himself into the chaotic, unvarnished reality of rural Southeast Asia. For weeks, he navigated narrow dirt roads on foot, eating twenty-cent plates of nasi goreng, sleeping on thin woven mats in 90-degree heat, and using bucket-flush squat toilets. He witnessed a world where the boundary between personal labor and survival didn't exist—where farmers worked the same small patches of land for ten generations. The journey only grew more intense as he reached India. In New Delhi, the air was thick with political tension, armed soldiers, and the purple smoke of street fires lit by the untouchables. Seeking the true soul of India, Bob took a grueling 15-hour train ride to Varanasi. Standing on the banks of the Ganges River, he watched a family place their father's body on a stack of logs, covering it in ghee and sandalwood before setting it ablaze. The acrid smell of burning flesh seared into his memory, a stark reminder of the fragile, visceral nature of human life. From there, he trekked into Nepal, accidentally trespassing on the King's heavily guarded private fishing pond, narrowly escaping jail time. But the climax of his journey occurred when his Pan Am flight was rerouted through Beirut, Lebanon. Thanks to strict media censorship in India, Bob had no idea that a brutal civil war had broken out. When his plane landed, it was forced to stop 500 yards from the terminal. Bob and his friends had to walk across the tarmac, surrounded by armed soldiers, listening to the crack of small-arms fire in the distance, and crunching over concrete rubble beneath walls riddled with bullet holes. An airline agent pulled them into a room and offered them a grim choice: stay in Beirut at their own risk, or get on the next plane to Paris. They chose Paris. Months later, walking over the pedestrian bridge at the San Francisco airport—30 pounds lighter and recovering from dysentery—Bob looked down at the gridlock of cars on the freeway. Instead of seeing traffic, he saw unparalleled opportunity. The stark contrast between the third world and America ignited a fire in him, cementing a vow to never waste the incredible privilege of being born in a place where success was possible.